The Deputy Chairman is elected by the Rajya Sabha itself from amongst its members. Whenever the office of the Deputy Chairman falls vacant, the Rajya Sabha elects another member to fill the vacancy.

The Deputy Chairman vacates his/her office in any of the following three cases:

1. if he/she ceases to be a member of the Rajya Sabha;
2. if he/she resigns by writing to the Chairman; and
3. if he/she is removed by a resolution passed by a majority of all the then members of the Rajya Sabha (i.e., an effective majority). Such a resolution can be moved only after giving 14 days' advance notice.

The Deputy Chairman performs the duties of the Chairman's office when it is vacant or when the Vice-President acts as President or discharges the functions of the President. He/she also acts as the Chairman when the latter is absent from the sitting of the House. In both the cases, he/she has all the powers of the Chairman.

It should be emphasised here that the Deputy Chairman is not subordinate to the Chairman. He/she is directly responsible to the Rajya Sabha.

Like the Chairman, the Deputy Chairman, while presiding over the House, cannot vote in the first instance; he/she can only exercise a casting vote in the case of a tie. Further, when a resolution for the removal of the Deputy Chairman is under consideration of the House, he/she cannot preside over a sitting of the House, though he/she may be present.

When the Chairman presides over the House, the Deputy Chairman is like any other ordinary member of the House. He/she can speak in the House, participate in its proceedings and vote on any question before the House.

Like the Chairman, the Deputy Chairman is also entitled to a regular salary and allowance. They are fixed by Parliament and are charged on the Consolidated Fund of India.



Panel of Vice-Chairpersons of Rajya Sabha

Under the Rules of Rajya Sabha, the Chairman nominates from amongst the members a panel of vice-chairpersons. Any one of them can preside over the House in the absence of the Chairman or the Deputy Chairman. He/she has the same powers as the Chairman when so presiding. He/she holds office until a new panel of vice-chairpersons is nominated.

When a member of the panel of vice-chairpersons is also not present, any other person as determined by the House acts as the Chairman.

It must be emphasised here that a member of the panel of vice-chairpersons cannot preside over the House, when the office of the Chairman or the Deputy Chairman is vacant. During such time, the Chairman's duties are to be performed by such member of the House as the President may appoint for the purpose. The elections are held, as soon as possible, to fill the vacant posts.



Secretariat of Parliament